Ron Hensley

ronkhensley@gmail.com

AAS in AI Software Engineering

PSYC100

Ethics in psychological research

Today
Welcome to your next lesson: Ethics in psychological research.

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've already learned, what's coming next, and how to build your understanding step by step.

Let’s get started — you’re moving forward, one step at a time.

Let’s start with a simple “then vs. now” picture using Milgram and Zimbardo

Here’s a quick comparison:

Study step	Milgram / Zimbardo (Then)	Modern version (Now, with ethics rules)
Before study	No independent ethics board	Must be reviewed and approved by an IRB
Consent form	Very vague, didn’t explain real risks	Informed consent: clear purpose, risks, right to quit
During study	Strong pressure to keep going, even when distressed	Participants can stop any time, no punishment
Harm	High emotional stress, little monitoring	Study must be minimal risk, constantly monitored
After study	Limited or delayed explanation	Debriefing: full explanation, support if upset

This is the big idea:

Today, research must pass through layers of protection (IRB, informed consent, debriefing, risk checks) that did not exist in Milgram and Zimbardo’s time.

Quick check-in:

When you look at that table, what jumps out to you most — the before part (how risky it was) or the now part (how many protections there are)?

just how open wth few restrictions things were the wolrd was a fdiffernt place

Yeah, it really was almost like the Wild West for research back then 😐 — lots of curiosity, very few brakes.

Let’s zoom in on one modern protection that exists because of how open things used to be: the IRB (Institutional Review Board).

IRB = an independent committee that reviews every study involving people to make sure it’s ethical before it starts.

It checks: “Are risks low? Are people informed? Is this fair?”

Simple way to see it:

Then: Milgram could design his study and just… run it.
Now: A group (IRB) must read the plan, ask hard questions, and can say no or change this.
Does the idea of an IRB feel more like:

A safety inspector for research
or
A creative partner helping improve studies

Which picture makes more sense to you right now?

saffety inspector

What do you think the IRB should do in that situation? Take your time with the question below 👇

You’re on an IRB reviewing a new study. The researcher wants to expose people to very stressful situations and does not clearly explain the risks in the consent form. Which IRB decision best matches the IRB’s safety inspector role?

A.

Approve it as is, because the science is interesting.

B.

Reject or require big changes, because risks and consent aren’t handled correctly.

C.

Ignore the risk details and focus only on whether the topic is new.

b

Nice choice — “safety inspector” fits really well here 🌓

Let’s build on that with one more concrete layer of protection: informed consent.

Very simply:

Informed consent = people agree to be in a study after they’re clearly told what will happen, what the risks are, and that they can quit anytime, no punishment.

Step-by-step, for a modern study:

Researcher explains the study in plain language.
Explains any risks (even mild ones, like stress or embarrassment).
Reminds them: “You can stop at any time, and it won’t affect your grades/job/etc.”
Participant signs (or clicks) to say: “I understand and I agree.”

In Milgram and Zimbardo, this was not done well:

People weren’t told clearly what might happen.
They felt like they couldn’t really quit.
Make sense so far — the difference between:

Just “sign here, trust us”
vs.

True informed consent, where people actually know what they're walking into?
Yes, that makes sense

What do you think this one is asking about? Take your time and pick the best answer 👇

A researcher tells participants: "This is a study about problem-solving. You might feel a bit stressed by the time limit, but you can stop at any time without penalty. Your answers are confidential." Then asks them to sign if they agree. What ethical protection is this an example of?

A.

Institutional Review Board (IRB) review

B.

Informed consent

C.

Debriefing after deception

D.

Risk/benefit analysis

Exactly right — informed consent 👀

Why your answer works:

The researcher explains the purpose ("study about problem-solving").
Mentions possible risk ("might feel a bit stressed").
States the right to quit ("stop at any time without penalty").
Mentions confidentiality of answers.
Then asks them to sign if they agree.

That's the classic informed consent package ☑

Next, I'd like to connect this to Milgram and Zimbardo and show how today's rules would have changed those studies.

Want to try a quick "If there'd been an IRB, what would they stop or change first?" scenario next?

Yes, I'm ready

Nice 😊 Let's do a quick IRB "what would they stop first?" using Milgram.

Here's a simple side□by□side:

Step in Milgram's study	What an IRB today would say
Participant is told it's a "memory study" and not the real purpose	"You must be more honest, or justify any deception very carefully."
Strong pressure to keep shocking ("You must continue")	"You cannot pressure people like that; they must feel free to stop."
No full explanation until long after	"You must debrief right after and check their well□being."

So IRBs today would mainly attack:

Deception that isn't justified
Pressure to keep going
Weak or delayed debriefing
I want to check your feel for this.

Imagine a new Milgram‑style study is proposed today, with fake shocks but real pressure to keep going.

Which part do you think the IRB would be MOST worried about:

The fake shocks themselves
or
The pressure to keep going even when the person is upset?
both to a degree as the gake shocks lead to stress but mostly the pressure to keep going and onot letting the person feely decide

Exactly — that's a strong read on it 🔍

You're right on two levels:

Fake shocks → create stress, so there is harm risk.
But the pressure to keep going, even when someone is upset, is the bigger ethical problem, because it attacks their freedom to choose and keeps them in a harmful situation.

That connects directly to one of the APA's core ideas:

Researchers must do good and avoid harm whenever possible, and must let people freely decide to stay or leave.

Next step, I want to introduce that first big APA principle (Beneficence & Non‑maleficence) using a tiny story and then have you test yourself on it.

Ready for that next piece?

Yes, I'm ready

Let's add that first big APA principle now 💡

Here's the core idea, in simple form:

Beneficence & Non‑maleficence = Do good, and avoid harm.

Help people when you can, and don't put them in danger or unnecessary distress.

Quick mini‑story:

A researcher runs an online anxiety study.

They use mild stress (a short timed test).
They give coping tips at the end.
If someone seems very distressed, they stop the session and offer resources.

That researcher is trying to learn something useful (benefit) while keeping harm as low as possible and stepping in if it gets too intense.

In Milgram's study, this principle was violated because people were pushed to extreme stress without enough protection or support.

Does this “do good / avoid harm” idea feel clear so far, or a bit fuzzy anywhere?

It's clear so far

What do you think fits best here? Take your time and pick the one that makes the most sense 👇

A researcher designs a study that may cause participants strong shame and anxiety, but there is no clear benefit to science or society. Which APA principle is MOST clearly being violated?

A.

Beneficence & Non-maleficence (do good, avoid harm)

B.

Fidelity & Responsibility (be trustworthy and accountable)

C.

Integrity (be honest and accurate)

D.

Justice (treat people fairly)

Nice work, Ron — you nailed that one again 🎯

You chose Beneficence & Non□maleficence (do good, avoid harm), and that’s exactly right because:

The study causes strong shame and anxiety → clear harm.
There is no clear benefit to science or society → little or no good.
So the balance is way off: high harm, low benefit → violates “do good, avoid harm.”
You’ve got a solid grip on that first principle.

Next, I’d like to introduce another one: Respect for People’s Rights & Dignity, especially how it connects to letting people freely choose (something you already noticed in Milgram).

Want to go there next?

Yes, let's continue

Great, let’s build on what you already noticed about freely choosing 👍

Here’s the next key APA principle:

Respect for People’s Rights & Dignity = respect people’s autonomy (their right to make their own choices), their privacy, and treat them with basic human respect.

Very concrete:

People must be free to say yes or no to a study.
They must be able to quit at any time without pressure or punishment.
Their personal info must be protected.
You don’t embarrass, humiliate, or degrade them.

In Milgram and Zimbardo:

Participants felt trapped or heavily pressured.
Some were humiliated or deeply distressed.
Their autonomy and dignity were not really respected.
Before I quiz you on this:

Does “Respect for People’s Rights & Dignity” mostly make sense if you think of it as:

“Don’t treat participants like tools. Treat them like full people who get to choose”?

Yes, that makes sense

What do you think fits best here? Take your time and choose the one that feels most right 👇

A lab study makes participants feel embarrassed in front of others and pressures them not to leave, even when they look very uncomfortable. Which APA principle is MOST clearly being violated?

A.

Beneficence & Non-maleficence (do good, avoid harm)

B.

Fidelity & Responsibility (be trustworthy and accountable)

C.

Integrity (be honest and accurate)

D.

Respect for People’s Rights & Dignity (respect autonomy, privacy, basic respect)

You’re on a roll, Ron 🎯

You picked Respect for People’s Rights & Dignity, and that’s exactly the heart of that scenario because:

They’re pressured not to leave → their autonomy (freedom to choose) is not respected.
They’re made to feel embarrassed in front of others → their dignity is being ignored.

That’s textbook disrespect for people’s rights and dignity.

From here, we still need to hit a few more pieces for this lesson:

How IRBs, deception rules, and debriefing work today
How protections evolved specifically after Milgram and Zimbardo

Do you want to:

Keep going with modern safeguards (IRB, deception, debriefing),
or
Pause here and quickly review the principles we’ve covered so far?
keep going

Nice, let’s keep moving forward 🚶‍♂️

You already understand IRB and informed consent, so I’ll add one more modern safeguard that’s huge after Milgram and Zimbardo: deception + debriefing.

Step by step:

Deception = when researchers temporarily don't tell participants the full truth about the study.
Today, deception is only allowed if:
It's really necessary to answer the question.
There is no good non-deceptive alternative.
The risk is low.
And then right after the study, researchers must:
Tell participants what was really going on (debriefing).
Explain why deception was used.
Check if they feel okay, and offer support if needed.
Sometimes, even give them a chance to withdraw their data once they know the truth.

So:

Modern rule = "If you must deceive, keep it safe, keep it minimal, and clean it up with a strong debrief."

Milgram did have some debriefing, but by today's standards it would need to be much more immediate, careful, and supportive.

Does this 2-part idea make sense so far?

Deception (temporary incomplete truth)
paired with
Debriefing (full explanation and support afterward)?
Yes, it makes sense

Great 👍

Now let's connect all this to how participant protection changed after Milgram and Zimbardo. I'll walk it in clear steps.

Here's how a modern Milgram-style study would be forced to change:

Before anything starts – IRB review

IRB would say:
"Risk of extreme stress is too high."
"You can't push people this hard."
"You must change the design or we won't approve it."
Consent form – real informed consent

Must warn about possible stress.
Must clearly say: "You can stop at any time without penalty."
No pretending it's just a harmless "memory" test with no hint of stress.
During the study – freedom to quit

No "You must continue" type scripts.
If someone looks very distressed, the researcher must stop or check on them.
Use of deception – stricter rules

If fake shocks are used, they must be:
Fully fake.
As mild and short as possible.
Justified as necessary.
IRB could still say: "Too intense; scale it way down."
After the study – immediate debriefing

Right away: “The shocks were fake, here’s what we were studying.”
Check how the person feels.
Offer support or referrals if needed.
Possibly allow them to remove their data if they’re upset.

All of that grew out of scandals and concerns around studies like Milgram (1961) and Zimbardo (1971).

I’d like to check this with a quick applied question next: I’ll give you a short “new Milgram” scenario and you’ll decide if an IRB should approve it, reject it, or demand changes.

Ready to try that?

I'm ready

What do you think is the best IRB response here? Take your time and choose the option that fits the ethics rules we’ve talked about 👇

A researcher proposes a “modern Milgram” study: participants think they are giving loud noise blasts to another person when they answer wrong. The noise is fake, but participants don’t know that. The script includes firm prompts like: “Please continue” and “The experiment requires that you go on,” even if the participant looks very upset. The researcher plans a short debrief at the end. As an IRB member, what is the BEST decision?

A.

Approve as is: the deception is fine and risk is minimal.

B.

Reject completely: any use of deception is unethical.

C.

Require major changes: reduce pressure to continue, strengthen debriefing, and better protect distressed participants.

D.

Approve only if participants are paid a high amount of money.

Beautiful IRB call there, Ron 🌓

You picked:

“Require major changes: reduce pressure to continue, strengthen debriefing, and better protect distressed participants.”

That’s exactly what a good IRB should do because:

Deception (fake noise) might be allowed if:
Risk is low
It’s necessary
It’s cleaned up with strong debriefing
But:
The strong pressure (“the experiment requires you to go on”) violates autonomy and Respect for People’s Rights & Dignity.
Watching people get very upset for the sake of data threatens Beneficence & Non□maleficence.
A quick, weak debrief isn’t enough for that level of stress.

So: not banned forever, but nowhere near acceptable “as is” → IRB demands big changes ☑

At this point you’ve shown you can:

Use APA principles (especially Beneficence & Respect for Rights & Dignity)
Think like an IRB member about Milgram□style designs
Explain how modern safeguards (IRB, consent, deception rules, debriefing) change these studies

We have one last thing for this lesson: a quick timeline view of how protections evolved after Milgram and Zimbardo, then we can call this lesson mastered if you're still feeling good.

Want to see that short "then → now" timeline next?

Yes, show me the timeline

Here's a simple "then → now" timeline for ethics in psychological research ⏱

Time	Event	What changed for participant protection
1961	Milgram obedience study	Sparked public shock about stress, pressure, and deception in labs.
Mid□1960s	First university IRBs start forming	Studies now need independent review before running.
1971	Zimbardo Stanford Prison Experiment	Showed how badly things can go when there's no oversight and roles get extreme.
Early 1970s (around 1973)	APA updates its Ethical Principles	Clearer rules on harm, consent, autonomy, and deception.
Today (current APA Code)	Full system: IRBs, informed consent, minimal risk standards, strict deception rules, required debriefing	Human participants are protected by multiple layers of safeguards.

Big picture:

Milgram and Zimbardo didn't just show how people obey or act in roles — they pushed the field to build the ethics system we use now.

Based on everything we've done, do you feel like you can now explain, in your own words, how participant protection improved after Milgram and Zimbardo?

If yes, we can wrap this lesson and move to the next one. If you'd like, I can give you one more practice scenario instead.

yes

Amazing work today, Ron 🎓

You've just mastered "Ethics in psychological research". Here's what you can now do:

Explain how Milgram (1961) and Zimbardo (1971) exposed serious ethical problems (stress, pressure, loss of autonomy, humiliation).
Show how that led to:
IRBs reviewing studies before they run
Stronger informed consent (clear info, real choice, right to quit)
Rules for deception + required debriefing
Focus on Beneficence & Non□maleficence and Respect for People's Rights & Dignity
Think like an IRB member and spot when a modern study needs big changes to protect participants.
You're not just memorizing terms — you're reasoning through real scenarios like a psychologist-in-training 🧠🔬

From here, your next lesson in General Psychology will build on this foundation and move deeper into how psychological forces shape behavior, but now with a clear sense of where the ethical lines are.

Before you click into the next lesson:

Anything from this ethics unit you’d like me to quickly restate in one sentence?
If not, you’re good to head to Learn → Next lesson whenever you’re ready.